

Start me up!

WHEN WAS THE LAST TIME YOU SAW A MOVIE

that was not geeky? Between superhero movies, reboots and sequels, it would be fairly normal for you to start feeling some geeky-movie fatigue. Heck, we've even had some members of our own team officially declaring that they are done with pop-culture references and cinematic universes that pander to a mass market. This fatigue isn't only limited to movies, it's about culture in general, social media overloads, tech company jargon hatred, and even start-up sickness! What's startup sickness? When you hear so much about something, that even seeing the word itself makes you throw up a little in your mouth....

One can see where such a sentiment comes from. So blatant is the trend of copycatting someone else's idea, that even venture capitalists want to know about other startups they can draw parallels from. In fact, it's like threading the eye of a needle in this regard, because if your idea has too many parallels, it's just another me-too, and if it has no parallels, then well, investors don't want to take the risk of investing at all. Given how many me-too startups have collapsed in recent times, this obviously needs to change. Remember how many cab aggregating services we had just a few years ago? How many have survived?

I still think it's wrong to assume a saturation of the startup market. You know why? Because this isn't the first startup wave in the history of humanity. Every single industry behemoth you see today – in pharmaceuticals, FNB, manufacturing, whatever – they were all startups once, and most of their "innovations" are done by smaller startups that have been quickly acquired.

So what's the next decade hold? Thanks to recent events, we're all aware of how crucial our data is to corporations and startups alike. Whether it's a globe-dominating social media company or a national-level digital payments startup, everyone has something to gain from your personal data.

Services are going to get ultra-personified. And I don't just mean Uber knowing when you usually travel to office and suggesting a ride, I mean Uber harnessing data from millions of users and devices like yours to prioritise longer, or higher-paying rides and also finding a way to pay drivers less, so that you're stuck with no one

wanting to take you to your office, because it's just not a "convenient" route. Instead of being rejected by humans taxi drivers, you will now be dumped by AI as well!

And the data that each startup has, when cross referenced with each other, can (and most certainly will) be used to create profiles of you not too different from the psychographic profiles that emerged at the heart of the recent Cambridge Analytica scandal. Think of it as something like a centralised user profile shared by multiple startups to pitch you services that may take advantage of your political, religious and personal biases – something that you haven't shared with the companies, but is pretty evident from a collective database of all the data about you online. Think about it, if you compliment a cab driver in an app rating for 'interesting conversations', you're likely to be paired with cabbies who are talkative, and not just that, they might use your social media profile to figure out what you want to talk about as well! Ordered only vegetarian food during a particular religious month? Prepare to get non-stop suggestions about local religious events.

So that's it? The next decade will be all about a data-hungry ecosystem of conscienceless startups? Not really. If the recent GDPR ruling and its fallout are anything to go by, startups are going to offload the burden of conscience increasingly to you and me over the next ten years. Forget the flood of GDPR spam asking for your consent to keep sending you spam, we are talking about platform-wide, or even category-wide, data privacy just because you said 'No'. On the other hand, if you don't really care and tap 'Yes', then strap yourself in. Because soon, thanks to advancements in AI, machine learning and big data, startups are all set to know enough about you to predict how you are going to use their services and do it for you. At that point, if you decide to look for the 'No' button, you'll be sorely disappointed.



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Let me know your thoughts on this column at:
@mukhornab |
arnab@digit.in